



▲ Robert-Houdin

This series of woodcuts from 1850 showcases some of Robert-Houdin's famous tricks, including, from left to right, the "garland of roses"; the "horn of plenty"; a mechanical trapeze artist; and the "crystal box trick," in which coins seemed to appear in a box suspended above the audience.

HOCUS POCUS

early stage magic

Two major developments characterized stage magic in the 19th century. Firstly, the kind of popular magic that had been practiced for centuries by itinerant conjurers at fairs and street markets was transformed initially into sophisticated drawing-room entertainments and then, increasingly, into lavish theatrical performances that drew mass

audiences. Secondly, its traditional tricks were joined by a throng of new illusions. Spectacular, startling, and improbable, they owed much to presentation—and even more to science.

The father of modern magic

These developments were epitomized by the performances of a Frenchman, Jean Eugène Robert-Houdin, by far the most influential of all 19th-century magicians and not to be confused with his later namesake, Harry Houdini (see p.259). Now known as "the father of modern magic," Robert-Houdin combined great technical sophistication with an effortless instinct for drama. He dazzled crowds across the globe and regularly performed before royalty. A one-time watchmaker, he made props of remarkable ingenuity, such as a magically flowering orange tree and a box that only a child could lift (it was held down by electromagnetism, which had only just been discovered). He was also a brilliant self-publicist, as were a number of his contemporaries: Isaiah Hughes, "the Fakir of Ava"; Scotsman John Henry Anderson, "the Great Wizard



◀ The medium of Inkerman

The meeting of science and magic was precisely encapsulated by Frenchman Henri Robin, who from the 1850s used electrically generated images to create ghostly figures, such as the drummer shown here.